

Kickoffs, Returns, and the Dynamic Kickoff

Why ten players stand still while the ball is in the air, and why a coach would rather you ran it back

Your team has just kicked a field goal. The kicker trots back to his own 35, and something strange happens: ten of his teammates jog *past* midfield and stop on the other team's 40, five yards from a row of opponents who are just standing there. Nobody moves. The kick goes up, hangs, and comes down at the 3, where a returner catches it and runs it back to the 28. The announcer says, approvingly, "That's the kick you want. They'd much rather have that than a touchback." Why would a coach prefer that the other team *return* the ball? Why were twenty players frozen in place while it was in the air? And why does this play look nothing like the kickoffs of five years ago? This chapter answers all three.

You'll be able to:

- Name every part of a dynamic kickoff on the broadcast (setup zone, landing zone, the two restraining lines, floaters) and say where the next drive will start for any kick, under the 2024, 2025 and 2026 rules.
- Explain why the league kept changing the kickoff, from the injury data that drove each change.
- Do the touchback math: say whether a kicker should kick into the end zone, into the landing zone, or squib it, and whether a returner should take a knee or run.
- Read a kickoff return as a run play: find the double team, the seal and the unblocked cover men.
- Explain onside kicks and the hands team under the current rules, and why surprise onside kicks no longer exist.
- Keep a field-position ledger for a game and compare it with the league average.

Before you start: this chapter leans on two earlier ones. Field Goals, Extra Points, and the Punting Game introduced the touchback, the fair catch and the punt return; The Language of the Run Game gave you the blocking words (double team, kick-out, seal, hat math) that a kickoff return now uses.

What a kickoff is, and why the game has one

A **kickoff** is the kick that starts each half and follows every touchdown and field goal: the team that just scored kicks the ball, off a tee, from its own 35 to the other team. It is the most common kind of **free kick**, a kick that puts the ball in play *without a snap*. The other free kicks are the kick a team makes after giving up a safety (from its own 20, and it may punt it instead of using a tee) and the rare fair-catch kick.¹

On every free kick, each team has a **restraining line**: a line it may not cross until the ball is kicked (and, since 2024, until the ball lands). Where those lines are drawn is the whole story of this chapter.

The two groups of eleven have names. The kicking team is the **kick coverage unit**: its job is to get down the field and tackle whoever catches the ball. The receiving team is the **return unit**: one or two returners and the nine or ten players who block for them. Both units are mostly backups (linebackers, safeties, tight ends, running backs), the players with a mix of size, speed and tackling ability, coached by the special teams coordinator.

! Why it exists

A kickoff is a way of handing the ball over after a score that is not free. The team that just scored gives the ball away, but gets to decide *how*: deep, short, high, bouncing, or into the end zone. The team receiving it gets a chance to gain field position with a return. Without a kickoff, every drive after a score would start at a fixed spot, and one of the game's few contests of speed in open space would disappear. That contest is also the problem: open space plus speed means violent collisions, and the history of the kickoff since 2009 is the league trying to keep the first part without the second.

The thing to hold on to is that a kickoff is a trade of **field position**. As Downs, Distance, and Field Position showed, yards are worth points: a first-and-10 at your own 20 is worth about 0.8 expected points, at your own 30 about 1.5, at your own 35 about 1.7

¹NFL, *Official Playing Rules*, Rule 6 (free kicks; the kick after a safety may be a punt, dropkick or placekick from the 20): <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/nfl-rulebook/>. The 2024 dynamic-kickoff explainer confirms the safety kick uses the same setup and landing zones, kicked from the 20: <https://www.nfl.com/news/2024-nfl-season-explaining-rules-for-new-dynamic-kickoff>.

(nflverse, 2023-2025). Every kickoff decides where on that curve the other team starts. A few yards per kickoff, over the eight or ten kickoffs in a game, is a real fraction of a point, and in a close game that can be the difference.

The kickoff you remember, and why the league kept changing it

For most of the last fifty years a kickoff looked like this. The kicker teed the ball up (at his own 35 from 1974, the 30 from 1994, and the 35 again from 2011) and ran up to it with his ten teammates in a line beside him.² The receiving team lined up ten yards away, at the kicking team's 45, with its returners back near the goal line. At the kick, everyone ran: the coverage sprinted downfield, and the receiving team's front line turned and ran back toward its own goal line to set up blocks for the return. For years those blockers formed a **wedge**, three or four big men shoulder to shoulder in front of the returner, and coverage players were coached to throw themselves at it.

Look at what that means physically. A coverage player has run 35 or 40 yards at full speed. The blocker he meets has turned around and is running back at him. Two players closing at something like 15 yards a second (roughly 30 miles an hour) collide, often helmet first. No other play in football routinely lined up that many collisions at that speed.

The data caught up with the intuition. The league's injury studies found concussions were far more likely on kickoffs than on ordinary plays: in 2017, about five times as likely, per play.³ So the rules moved, one patch at a time:

- **2009:** wedges limited to two players.⁴
- **2011:** the kickoff moved from the 30 to the 35. A kicker five yards closer drives more kicks into the end zone, and a kick that stays there is a touchback: no return, no collisions. Touchbacks jumped from 16% of kickoffs in 2010 to 43% in 2011.⁵
- **2016:** the kickoff touchback moved from the 20 to the 25, to make kneeling more attractive.⁶
- **2018:** a full redesign. No running start (the coverage had to stand still, within a yard of the ball, until the kick); five coverage players on each side of the ball; eight of the receiving team's players inside a 15-yard "setup zone" near the ball; wedges banned outright; no blocking in that zone until the ball was touched or hit the ground.⁷
- **2023:** a one-year patch let the returner fair-catch a kickoff anywhere inside his own 25 and take the ball at the 25, the same as a touchback.⁸

Every patch worked the same way: it made the kickoff safer by making it *disappear*. By 2023 only about a quarter of kickoffs were returned, the fewest on record, and the play was close to a formality: a kick into the end zone, a knee, the ball at the 25.⁹ There was open talk about abolishing it.

²The kickoff spot moved from the 40 to the 35 in 1974, to the 30 in 1994 and back to the 35 in 2011: "Kickoff (gridiron football)," *Wikipedia*: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kickoff_\(gridiron_football\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Kickoff_(gridiron_football)); NFL Football Operations, "Evolution of the NFL rules": <https://operations.nfl.com/the-rules/evolution-of-the-nfl-rules/>.

³Concussions were about five times as likely on kickoffs as on other plays in 2017, with 71 kickoff concussions in 2015-17: NFL.com, "Kickoff changes could include eliminating running start" (2018): <https://www.nfl.com/news/kickoff-changes-could-include-eliminating-running-start-0ap3000000930999>; see also ESPN, "Proposal trying to make NFL kickoffs more like a punt play" (2018): https://www.espn.com/nfl/story/_/id/23385442/proposal-trying-make-nfl-kickoffs-more-punt-play.

⁴The 2009 rule banned wedges of three or more blockers (two-man wedges stayed legal until 2018): Sports Illustrated (2018), cited in the 2018 note below, which says the league had "restricted them to two-man wedges in 2009."

⁵Course calculation from nflverse play-by-play (regular season), done in the code cells of this chapter. Return rate = kickoffs with a listed returner, as a share of all kickoffs including onside kicks (25.2% in 2023, 32.9% in 2024, 74.6% in 2025, matching other published counts of about 22%, 33% and 75%). Drive start = the yard line of the receiving team's next play, excluding onside kicks and return touchdowns. Touchback rate uses the pbp `touchback` flag. Onside recovery uses `own_kickoff_recovery` on kicks whose description says "onside."

⁶The kickoff touchback moved from the 20 to the 25 in 2016, first as a one-year trial: "Kickoff (gridiron football)," *Wikipedia* (above).

⁷Sports Illustrated, "The NFL's New Kickoff Rules, Explained" (Sept 7, 2018): <https://www.si.com/nfl/2018/09/07/nfl-kickoff-rule-changes-explained-onside-return-clarified>.

⁸The 2023 rule let a receiver fair-catch a kickoff inside his 25 and take the ball at the 25; the dynamic kickoff replaced it in 2024: "Kickoff (gridiron football)," *Wikipedia* (above), and the course fact sheet.

⁹Course calculation (method in the earlier calculation note): 25.2% of 2023 regular-season kickoffs were returned, the lowest rate in the nflverse data back to 1999.

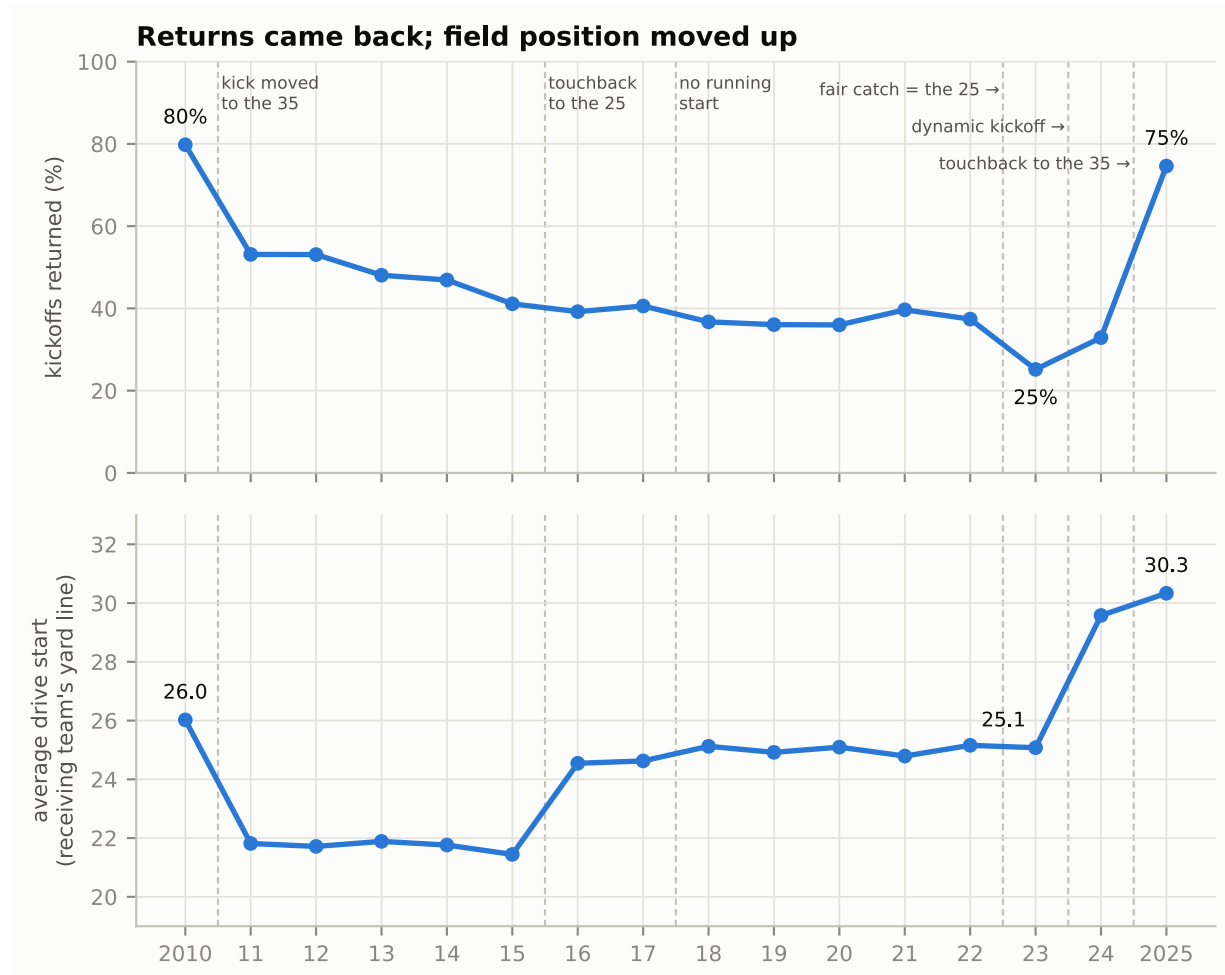


Figure 1: Kickoff returns and starting field position, NFL regular seasons 2010-2025. Top: the share of all kickoffs that were returned. Each dashed line marks a rule change. Moving the kickoff to the 35 (2011) and the touchback to the 25 (2016) pushed the return rate down for a decade, to its low in 2023; the dynamic kickoff brought returns back, and moving the touchback to the 35 in 2025 brought them back to 2010 levels. Bottom: where the receiving team's drive started, on average, after kickoffs (onside kicks and return touchdowns excluded). It moved up four yards in 2024 and stayed there. Data: nflverse play-by-play; course calculation.

Read the chart left to right as a decade of trying to have it both ways. Every change before 2024 pushed the return rate down, and the bottom panel shows the cost: when the touchback was at the 20, drives after kickoffs started around the 22; when it moved to the 25, they started around the 25. The league was buying safety with boredom. The 2024 change is the first one that sent *both* lines up.

The dynamic kickoff, piece by piece

The fix came from outside the NFL. The XFL, a spring league, opened in 2020 with a kickoff invented by its director of football operations, innovation and strategy, Sam Schwartzstein, a former Stanford center who simulated the idea more than a thousand times before the league used it. His insight was to keep the return but take away the run-up: line the two teams up close together, and freeze them until the ball comes down.¹⁰ When the NFL's competition committee went looking for a way to save the play, NFL special teams coaches, among them the Cowboys' John Fassel, presented the XFL model to the committee, and the owners adopted an NFL version for 2024 as a one-year trial.¹¹ It is called the **dynamic kickoff**. Here is the 2026 version.

¹⁰Gilberto Manzano, "Happy Returns: NFL's New Dynamic Kickoff 'Will Look Weird,'" *Sports Illustrated* (Sept 5, 2024): <https://www.si.com/nfl/happy-returns-new-dynamic-kickoff-will-look-weird>.

¹¹On Fassel presenting the XFL-based model to the competition committee: *Sports Illustrated* (Cowboys Country), <https://www.si.com/nfl/cowboys/news/dallas-cowboys-john-fassel-kickoff-overhaul-rule-changes-xfl>. On the 2024 rules as a one-year trial: <https://www.nfl.com/news/2024-nfl-season-explaining-rules-for-new-dynamic-kickoff>.

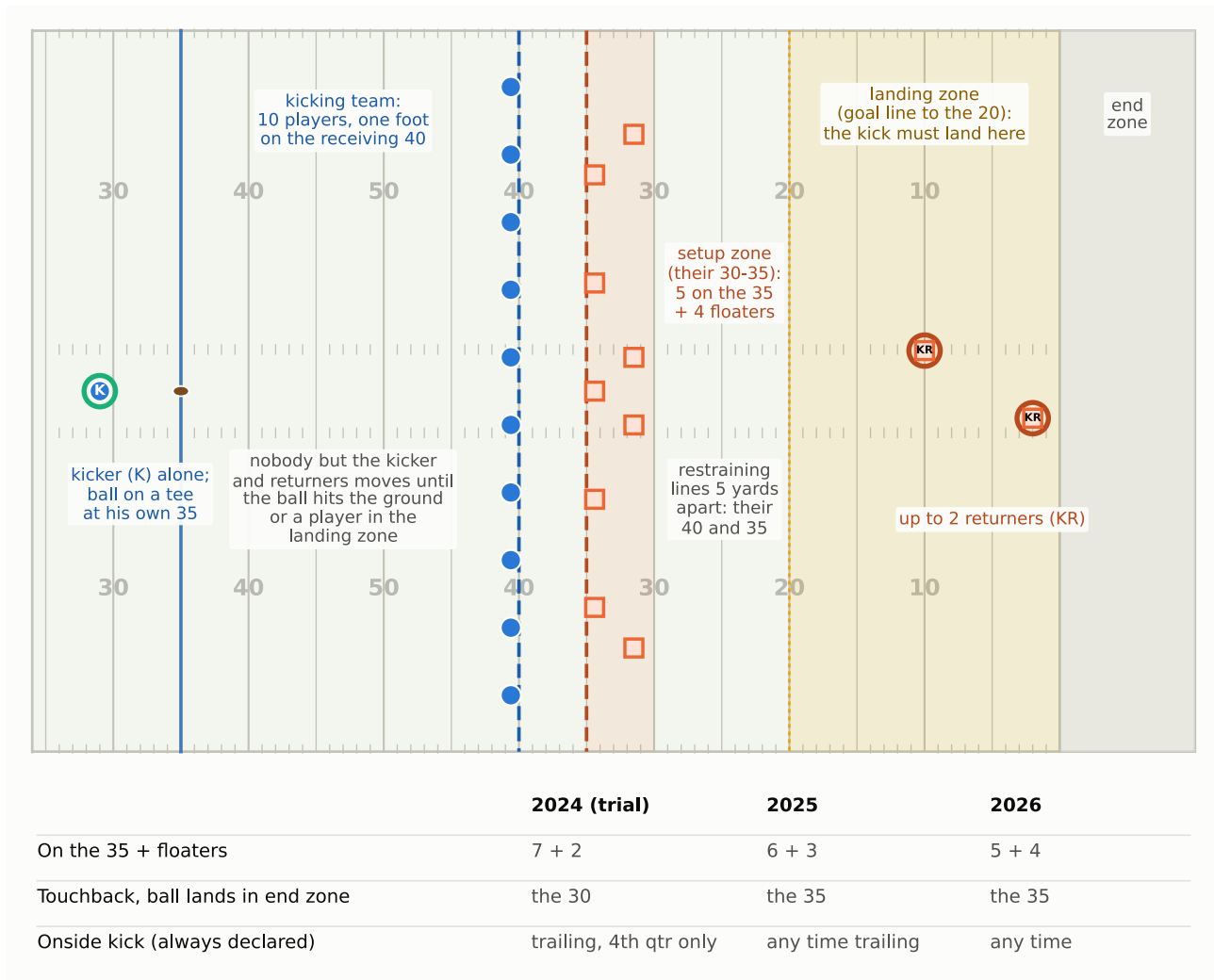


Figure 2: The dynamic kickoff under the 2026 rules, kicking left to right. The kicker (K) is alone at his own 35, the only kicking-team player on his side of midfield. His ten teammates stand with one foot on the receiving team's 40 (the kicking team's restraining line, blue dashes). Five yards away, the receiving team has five players on its own 35 (its restraining line, orange dashes) and four 'floaters' behind them in the setup zone (their 30 to 35, shaded orange). Up to two returners (KR) wait in the landing zone (goal line to the 20, shaded gold), where the kick has to come down. The table below the field shows what changed in 2025 and 2026.

Walk through it from left to right.

The kicker is alone. He kicks from his own 35, as before, but he is the only kicking-team player on his side of the 50, and he may not cross midfield until the ball touches the ground or a player.¹² In practice he becomes the last line of defense: a safety with a kicking leg.

The coverage starts on the other team's 40. His ten teammates line up with one foot on the receiving team's 40, 25 yards in front of the tee. That is the kicking team's restraining line. They may not move until the ball hits the ground, or hits a player in the landing zone or end zone.

The blockers start five yards away. The receiving team's restraining line is its own 35. Behind it is the **setup zone**, the five yards between the 35 and the 30, where at least nine receiving players line up. In 2024, seven of them had to have a foot on the 35 and the other two lined up behind them, outside the hash marks. The league has loosened that every year since: in 2025 six on the line and up to three behind; from 2026, only five on the line and up to four behind. The players behind the line are called **floaters**,

¹²NFL.com, "2024 NFL season: Explaining rules for new dynamic kickoff": <https://www.nfl.com/news/2024-nfl-season-explaining-rules-for-new-dynamic-kickoff>. 2025 changes (made permanent; touchback to the 35; onside whenever trailing): <https://www.nfl.com/news/nfl-owners-vote-to-make-dynamic-kickoff-permanent-adjust-ball-spot-on-touchbacks-to-35-yard-line> and <https://operations.nfl.com/rules-officiating/featured-rules>.

¹³2026 rule changes, approved March 31, 2026 (onside kick declarable at any time; five receiving players required on the restraining line, with up to four off it and limits on overloading; touchbacks and kicks out of bounds from the 50 spotted at the 20): Vikings.com, "NFL rule changes and bylaws, 2026 season": <https://www.vikings.com/news/nfl-rule-change-bylaws-annual-league-meetings-2026-season>; Football Zebras, "NFL owners approve rule

and the 2026 rule bars a team from bunching all of them in front of the returners: they have to be spread across the field.¹³ The setup-zone players are frozen too, until the ball lands or is touched.

The returners wait in the landing zone. The **landing zone** is the area between the receiving team's goal line and its 20. Up to two returners stand there, and they are the only players besides the kicker allowed to move before the ball comes down.

The kick has to land in the landing zone. That is the rule that makes the whole thing work, and it is enforced with field position, not flags. A kick that lands short of the landing zone, or goes out of bounds, gives the receiving team the ball at its own 40. A kick that lands in the landing zone is live, and it must be returned (no fair catches, no kneeling where it lands). A kick that carries into the end zone can be returned or downed for a touchback. The chart below is the map.

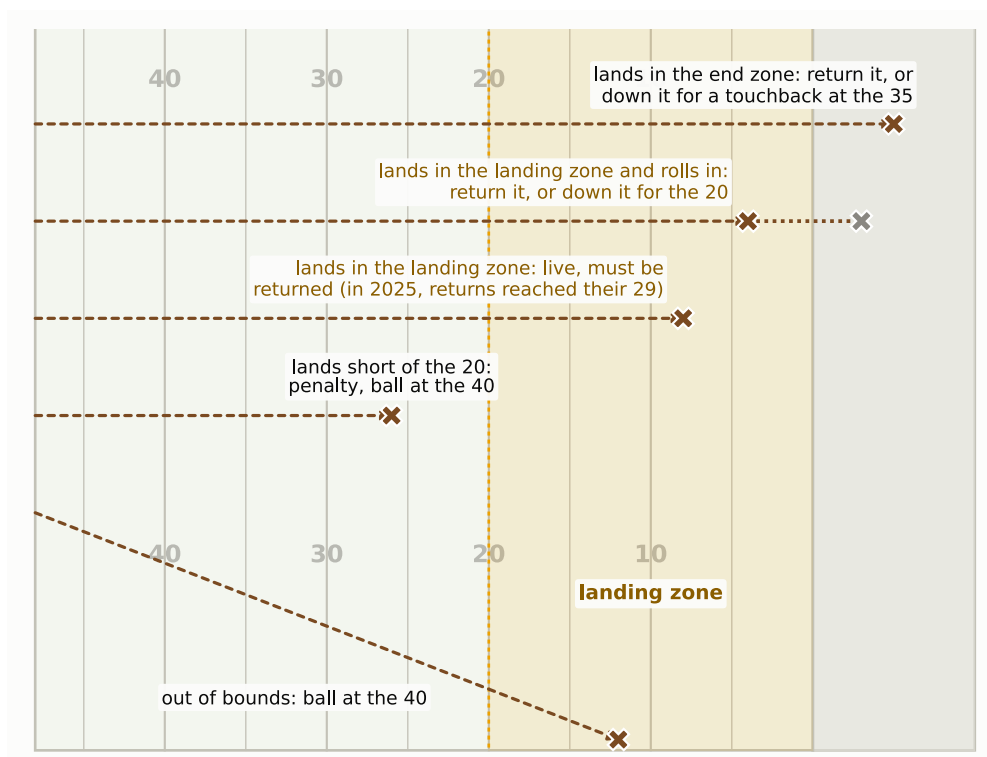


Figure 3: Where the kick comes down decides where the next drive starts (2025-2026 rules, kicking from the 35, left to right). Short of the 20 or out of bounds: the receiving team starts at its 40, a big penalty in field position. In the landing zone (gold): the ball is live and must be returned; in 2025 those returns ended, on average, near the 29. In the landing zone and then rolling into the end zone (dotted): the returner may run it out or down it for the 20, the best result a kicker can hope for. In the end zone on the fly: return it, or down it for a touchback at the 35.

changes for the 2026 season": <https://www.footballzebras.com/2026/04/nfl-owners-approve-rule-changes-for-the-2026-season/>; Seahawks.com: <https://www.seahawks.com/news/nfl-announces-approved-rule-changes-for-2026-season>.

Table 1: Where the receiving team starts its drive, by rule and season. Kicks are from the 35 unless noted; the 2026 column shows the rules changed after the 2025 season.

Where the kick ends up	2024	2025	2026
Lands short of the landing zone, or out of bounds	the 40	the 40	the 40
Lands in the landing zone	live: must be returned	same	same
Lands in the landing zone, rolls into the end zone, downed	the 20	the 20	the 20
Lands in the end zone (or goes out the back), downed	the 30	the 35	the 35
Kicked from the 50 after a penalty: touchback or out of bounds	the 30 / the 25	the 30 / the 25	the 20 / the 20

The last row is the newest wrinkle, and it shows how carefully teams read these rules. When a penalty on the receiving team moves the kickoff to the 50, the kicker is suddenly 15 yards closer. In 2025 a team in that spot was better off kicking the ball out of bounds *on purpose*, because out of bounds put the receiving team at its 25 while a touchback put it further out. Dallas tried exactly that against Kansas City in 2025.¹⁴ For 2026 the league closed the loophole: a kick from the 50 that results in a touchback or goes out of bounds now gives the receiving team the ball at its 20, so a deep, in-bounds kick is the better choice again.¹⁵

! Why it exists

The dynamic kickoff attacks the two things that made the old kickoff dangerous: **distance** and **speed**. Nobody gets a running start, and the coverage starts five yards from the players who will block it, so by the time two players meet they have run a few yards, not forty. The return survives because the kick has to land where it can be returned, and the touchback is set deliberately high so that kneeling is not free. The trade-off: the play looks strange, kick strategy became complicated (the rest of this chapter), and the coverage team now has very little time to beat blocks.

Did it work? In the 2024 season, the league reported that the concussion rate on kickoffs fell 43% against the 2021-2023 average, while returns rose 57%.¹⁶ That is the combination every earlier change had failed to deliver.

i Madden vs. real life

In older video games the kickoff is a meter: press the button, pick the power, watch a cutscene. On a real NFL field in 2026 it is a designed play on both sides. The kicking team has a plan for exactly where the ball should land and how long it should hang; the return team has a blocking scheme, called in the huddle like a run play, that depends on where it expects the kick. Special teams coordinators spend as much time on kickoffs now as on any unit they coach.

Old and new, side by side

The clearest way to see the change is to put the two alignments next to each other and draw what happens in the first few seconds.

¹⁴CBS Sports, “NFL Competition Committee approves five rule changes for 2026 season”: <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/nfl-rule-changes-2026> (“Dallas tried to take advantage of this loophole last season against the Chiefs by intentionally kicking the ball out of bounds to pin Kansas City at its own 25-yard line”).

¹⁵The 2026 fix, approved March 31, 2026: touchbacks and kicks out of bounds on kickoffs from the 50 are spotted at the 20 (Football Zebras and Vikings.com, cited in the 2026-rules note above).

¹⁶NFL, “Concussions decrease to historic low in 2024 NFL season” (2025): the kickoff concussion rate fell 43% against the 2021-2023 average, returns rose 57% in the regular season, and there were seven kickoff-return touchdowns: <https://www.nfl.com/news/concussions-decrease-to-historic-low-in-2024-nfl-season>.

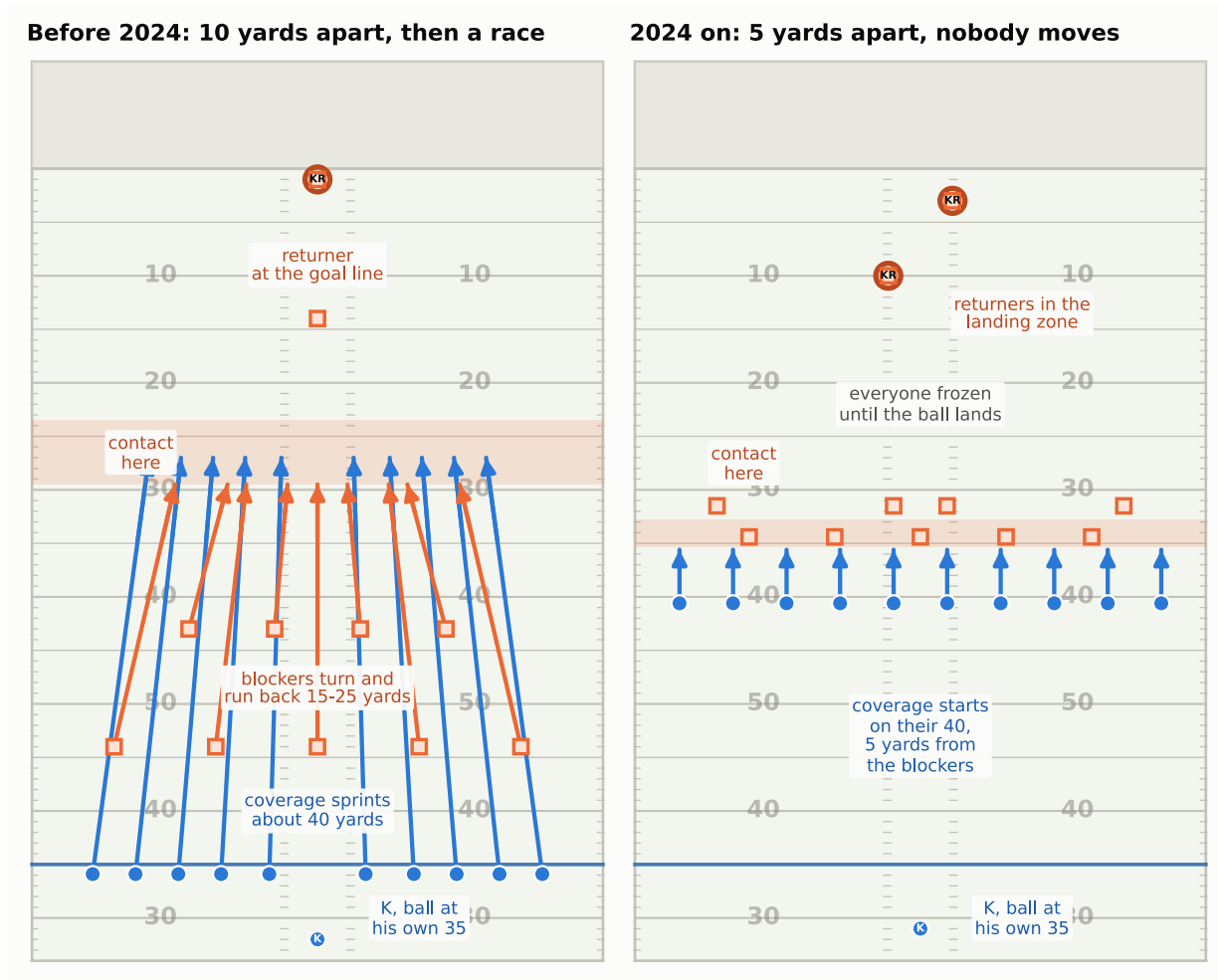


Figure 4: The traditional kickoff (left, as played from 2018 to 2023) and the dynamic kickoff (right, 2026 alignment), both kicked up the page from the kicking team's 35. Left: the coverage lines up beside the ball and the receiving team ten yards away; at the kick, the coverage sprints about 40 yards while the blockers turn and run back 15 to 25 yards, so the two groups meet at speed around the receiving team's 25-30 (shaded). Right: the coverage stands on the receiving team's 40, five yards from the blockers, and nobody moves until the ball lands; contact comes after a few yards of running, around the receiving team's 33-35 (shaded).

Three differences matter, and each one has a "why":

1. **Where the collisions happen.** On the left, contact comes around the receiving team's 25 or 30, after both groups have run a long way. On the right, it comes near the receiving team's 35, almost where both groups started. Less running before contact means less speed at contact, and the energy in a collision grows with the *square* of speed: halve the closing speed and you cut the energy to a quarter.
2. **Who decides when the play starts.** On the left, the kick started everything. On the right, the ball *landing* starts everything. That shifts the drama from the kicker's leg to his accuracy and hang time, which is the subject of the next sections.
3. **What a return looks like.** On the left, a return was a sprint behind a wall of blockers who had turned their backs to the coverage. On the right, it is much closer to a running play: blockers facing the defenders they will block, a few yards apart, with a ball carrier coming at them from behind.

🔥 Common misconception

"The new kickoff is safer because there are fewer returns." The opposite: there are far *more* returns than in any season since 2010 (the chart above), and the injury rate went *down*. The old rules made the play safer by eliminating it; the new rules made the play itself safer.

Kick to tackle: how a return is blocked now

Here is one return from start to finish, drawn as four moments: the ball in the air, the catch, the blocks, the tackle. Read the panels first; the rest of this section explains what you are seeing.



Figure 5: A dynamic-kickoff return, kick to tackle (simulated, BDB-format tracking; kicking team in blue, moving up the page; the circled returner catches at his 2). Panel 1: the ball is in the air and twenty players stand still; only the kicker and the two returners move. Panel 2: the catch releases everyone. Panel 3 (zoomed): each blocker steps to his man; one seals a cover man to the inside (left), two double-team the next one and drive him outward, and the lane opens between them. The second returner leads through it to kick out the next cover man. Panel 4: the returner reaches the 33, where the two players the scheme left unblocked, the far-side cover man and the kicker, arrive together. That is a good return under these rules.

A return under the dynamic kickoff is a run play with a twist: the “snap” is the moment the ball comes down, and nobody knows exactly when or where that will be until the kicker kicks. Start with the arithmetic, the same hat math a run play uses.

The coverage team has **eleven** potential tacklers: ten on the 40, plus the kicker. The return team has nine blockers in the setup zone, plus the second returner if it uses two: **ten** blockers at most, and one of the eleven “hats” will always be unblocked. A return scheme starts by choosing *which* defenders to leave alone. The usual answer is the cover men farthest from where the return is

going (they have the longest way to run) and the kicker (who starts 25 yards behind everyone else). Leave those alone and you can spend a spare blocker on a double team at the point of attack, which is exactly what coaches began doing in 2024.¹⁷

The return in the panels above is a middle return slightly to the right. Watch the returner (circled) and the gap he runs through.

What to take from the four panels:

- **Nothing happens for almost four seconds.** That is the hang time of the kick, and for the whole of it the blockers and the coverage stand five yards apart doing nothing. When you watch on Sunday, use those seconds: count the floaters, find the double team before it happens (two blockers lined up close to one cover man), and guess the return's direction.
- **The blocks are run-game blocks.** The blocker who keeps his man inside is making a seal block; the two who take one man together are a double team, the same idea as a combo block on the line; the second returner leading through the hole and hitting the first defender to show is a lead block that ends as a kick-out. A punt return, by contrast, is usually built around a return wall set up along one sideline, because punt blockers have much more time and space.
- **The scheme decides who is unblocked.** This return leaves the far-side cover man and the kicker free, and they make the tackle. Good kick-coverage units know this, which is why the coverage players farthest from the ball sprint *across* the field rather than straight ahead: they are the ones the return cannot afford to block.
- **The ceiling is low and the floor is high.** With the coverage only five yards away when the ball comes down, most returns are stopped somewhere between the 25 and the 35. Big returns still happen, but they need a missed tackle by one of the unblocked men.

! Why it exists

Why double-team anybody when you are already a blocker short? Because a one-on-one block between a blocker standing still and a cover man running at him is a coin flip, and the return only needs one lane. Spending two blockers on the cover man aligned in the lane turns that coin flip into a near-certainty, and the cost (an unblocked man on the far side) is paid in time: he has 20-plus yards farther to run. Under the old rules, double teams and wedges were restricted for safety, because they met players running at full speed. With players starting five yards apart, the league allows them, and returns built on them became the fashion within weeks of the 2024 opener.¹⁸

The kicker's menu: touchback, landing zone, or squib

Now the question from the start of the chapter. Under the 2025-26 rules the kicker has four basic choices:

1. **Kick it into the end zone.** The returner will usually kneel, and the receiving team starts at its 35.
2. **Kick it high and deep into the landing zone,** ideally near the goal line, so that it is caught around the 2 or 3 with the coverage closing as it comes down, or bounces and rolls into the end zone.
3. **Kick it low and bouncing** into the landing zone, a **squib kick**: hard to field cleanly, often aimed at a blocker rather than the returner, and hard to return far. Coaches also call a line-drive kick that bounces awkwardly a "bounce kick."
4. **Kick it somewhere else:** short of the landing zone or out of bounds, which costs a penalty and gives the ball at the 40. Nobody does this on purpose (except, in 2025, from the 50).

The answer comes from comparing where drives start after each one. Here is every returned kickoff from the last two seasons, grouped by where the returner fielded the ball.

¹⁷The Ringer, "The Definitive Guide to the NFL's New Dynamic Kickoff" (Sept 12, 2024), on the Bears' Week 1 double team (credited to ESPN's Ben Solak), eight other teams trying double teams, and Blake Grupe's first nine kickoffs landing at or inside the 5: <https://www.theringer.com/2024/09/12/nfl/nfl-2024-new-dynamic-kickoff-definitive-guide>.

¹⁸The Ringer (Sept 12, 2024), cited above, on double teams spreading to at least eight teams after Week 1 of 2024.

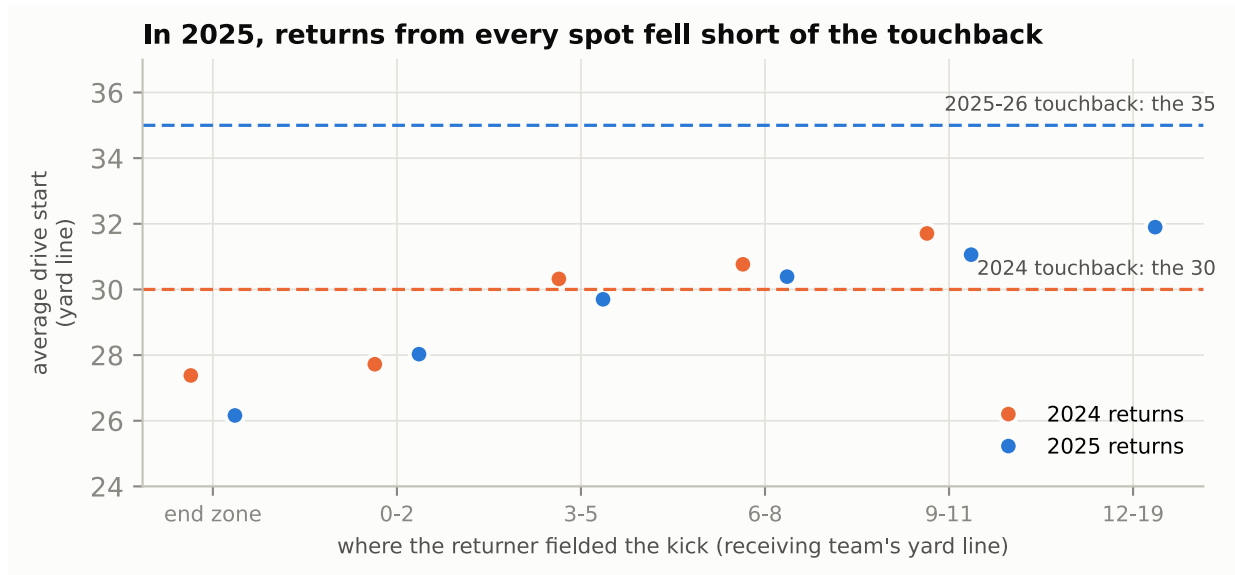


Figure 6: The touchback math. Each dot is the average drive start for returned kickoffs, grouped by where the returner fielded the ball, in 2024 (orange) and 2025 (blue); buckets with fewer than 30 returns are left out. Dashed lines: the touchback spot, the 30 in 2024 and the 35 in 2025-26. In 2025 returns from every spot fell short of the 35, and the deeper the kick was fielded, the worse the return team did: that is why kickers aim deep into the landing zone. In 2024, kicks fielded past the 2 were usually returned beyond the 30, one reason most kickers then preferred the end zone. Data: nflverse play-by-play, regular season, kicks from the 35; course calculation.

Two things jump out.

In 2025, every returnable kick was a better deal for the kicking team than a touchback. Kicks fielded at the goal line led to drives starting around the 28; kicks fielded at the 10, around the 31. All of them are short of the 35 the touchback would have given. In expected-points terms (the first section), the difference between starting at the 35 and the 30 is about 0.2 points, every time. The nflverse play values say the same thing in one line: in 2025 a kickoff that was returned was worth, on average, +0.19 expected points to the receiving team, and a touchback +0.47. A kick into the landing zone that bounced into the end zone and was downed at the 20 was worth -0.38. Those numbers already include the risk: the occasional long return and return touchdown, and the occasional fumble.

The league set the touchback at the 35 on purpose. In 2024, with the touchback at the 30, kicking into the end zone was the safe, nearly break-even choice, and most teams took it: 64% of kickoffs were touchbacks. Moving it to the 35 made the touchback a *gift* of field position, so kickers stopped giving it. The touchback rate fell to 21% in 2025, and the return rate went from 32.9% to 74.6%.¹⁹ That is the touchback acting as a price, set by the league to buy returns.

So why does anyone still kick it into the end zone? Because a landing-zone kick has its own risks: a kick that comes up short of the 20 is a disaster (the ball at the 40), and a kick that is caught at the 15 with the coverage still far away can be returned a long way. Some kickers trust their accuracy and hang time more than others, and some coverage units are better than others. Late in a half, the clock changes the math too (Drill 2 below).

¹⁹Course calculation (method as above): touchbacks were 64.3% of kickoffs in 2024 and 20.7% in 2025.

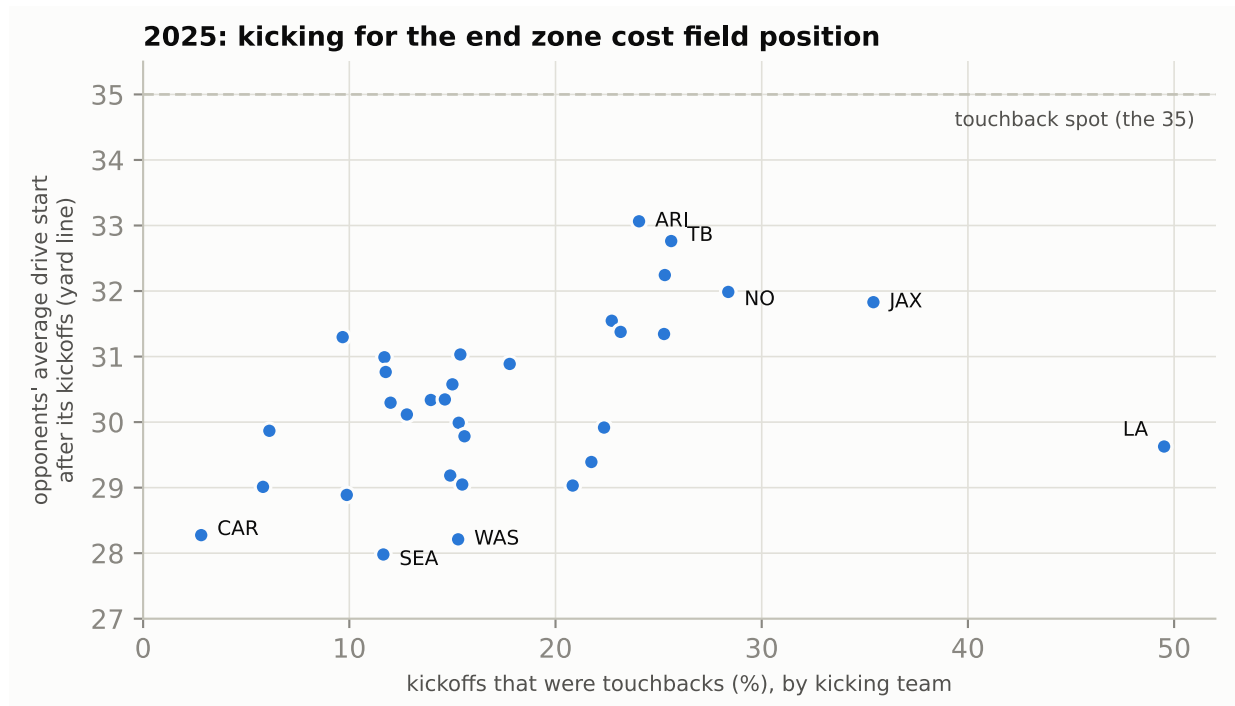


Figure 7: 2025, by kicking team: the share of its kickoffs that went for touchbacks (across) against where its opponents started their drives after its kickoffs, on average (up; lower is better for the kicking team). Teams that kicked more touchbacks tended to give up better field position, but the scatter is loose: Seattle and Carolina kicked into the landing zone and covered well, the Rams kicked half their kickoffs into the end zone and still did better than average, and Arizona and Tampa Bay gave up the most field position.

Kicker accuracy and coverage matter as much as the policy. Data: nflverse play-by-play, regular season; course calculation.

The squib deserves a word of its own. A squib is a low kick that bounces and skids through the landing zone. Because it is live the moment it lands, the coverage is released immediately, and because it bounces unpredictably, the receiving team often has a blocker in the setup zone or the second returner field it rather than the dangerous returner. You see it most at the end of a half, when the kicking team wants to take away any chance of a long return, and against returners who are simply too good to kick to. Its risks are the mirror of its advantages: it gives up a few yards of field position, and a squib that dies short of the 20 is a 40-yard-line penalty.

The returner's decision: kneel or run?

The returner has a menu too, and it hinges on one detail that the broadcast rarely explains: **where the ball first hit the ground**.

- If the kick came down **in the end zone**, kneeling gives his team the ball at the 35. Running it out has to beat the 35 to be worth it, and in 2025 it usually didn't: the 125 kicks returned from the end zone started, on average, at the 26, and only 9% reached the 35.²⁰
- If the kick came down **in the landing zone and rolled into the end zone**, kneeling only gets the 20. Now running it out is almost always right.
- If the kick came down **in the landing zone and stayed there**, he has no choice: he must return it.

Watch for returners getting this wrong. A returner who catches the ball two yards deep in the end zone and runs it out into a wall of coverage at the 22 has cost his team about 0.9 expected points against a knee.

Onside kicks and the hands team

An **onside kick** is the kicking team's attempt to get the ball back. Any kickoff becomes a free ball once it has traveled 10 yards (or once a receiving player touches it), and either team may recover it. So the kicker hits a short, hard, bouncing kick, usually toward one sideline, and his teammates try to get to it after it passes the 10-yard mark. The classic technique is to drive the top of the ball into the ground so it takes one big hop, high enough to come down where the kicking team's players are arriving.

²⁰Course calculation (method as above): 2025 regular-season kickoffs from the 35 fielded behind the goal line and returned.

The receiving team's answer is the **hands team**: when it expects an onside kick, it replaces its usual blockers with its surest-handed players (receivers, tight ends, running backs and defensive backs), lined up close to the ball, whose only job is to catch or smother a bouncing kick.

The onside kick has a different alignment from the dynamic kickoff: the kicking team lines up beside the ball, not on the 40, and the receiving team ten yards away, much like the old kickoff.²¹ And under every version of the dynamic kickoff, an onside kick has to be **declared** to the officials before the kick. In 2024 it was allowed only for a team trailing in the fourth quarter; from 2025 any time a team is trailing; and from 2026, changed after the 2025 season, at any time at all, even when ahead.²²

That word “declared” changed the play completely. A surprise onside kick, the most famous trick play in the kicking game, is now illegal: the receiving team always knows it is coming, so the hands team is always on the field. And the rule changes since 2018 had already taken away the running start that made onside kicks recoverable. The result is that the recovery rate collapsed. Under the dynamic kickoff, declared onside kicks were recovered by the kicking team 6% of the time in 2024 and 10% in 2025 (about 50 tries a season, so the second figure is noisy).²³ The league's head of football operations, Troy Vincent, said in October 2025 that a recovery rate under 5% might push the owners to “revisit” the play.²⁴ A proposed alternative, letting a trailing team keep the ball by converting a fourth-and-long play from scrimmage instead, has been voted down or withdrawn several times.²⁵

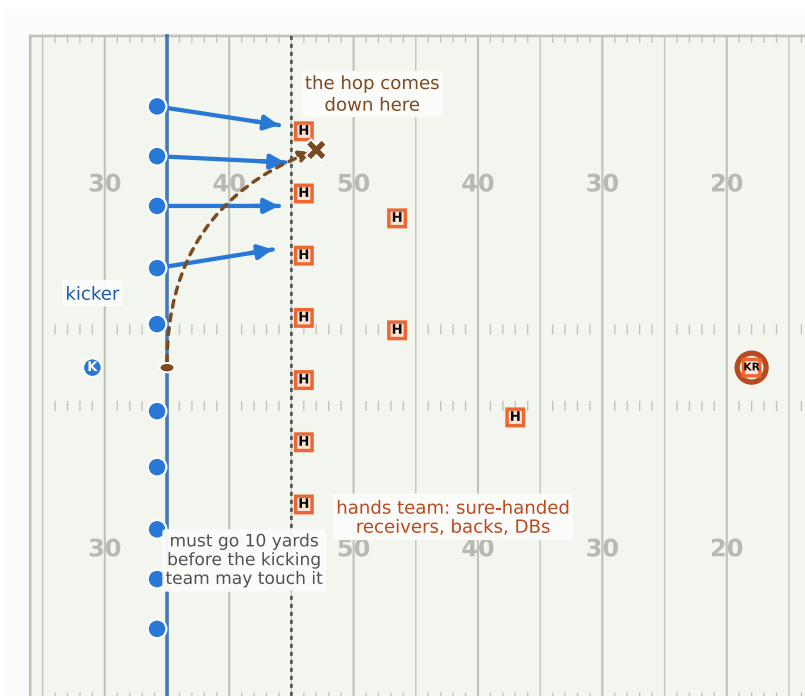


Figure 8: A declared onside kick (generic; the exact onside alignment rules are in the 2026 rulebook). The kicking team lines up beside the ball, five on each side; the receiving team puts its hands team (orange) ten or more yards away. The kicker drives the ball into the ground toward one sideline (here the offense's left, the top of the picture) so it takes a big hop past the 10-yard line, and the kicking team's players on that side race to it. The hands team's front line (H) has to catch it or fall on it; once the ball goes 10 yards, it belongs to whoever recovers it.

²¹On the onside alignment and the declaration requirement: NFL.com 2024 explainer (above) and Jeff Kerr, “New kickoff rule has improvements for 2025, but there's still one change NFL needs to address,” CBS Sports (Sept 3, 2025): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/new-kickoff-rule-has-improvements-for-2025-but-theres-still-one-change-nfl-needs-to-address> (onside kicks recovered 6.45% of the time under the dynamic kickoff in 2024).

²²The 2026 onside rule, approved March 31, 2026: “to permit the kicking team to declare an onside kick at any time during the game” (Vikings.com, cited above). The 2024 and 2025 versions: NFL.com and NFL Football Operations, cited in the 2024-rules note.

²³Course calculation (method as above): kickoffs whose play description says “onside,” and how often the kicking team recovered (own_kickoff_recovery).

²⁴Stephen Whyno, Associated Press, “NFL sees a surge in returns with the new dynamic kickoff; onside kicks remain a concern” (Oct 21, 2025): <https://www.clickondetroit.com/sports/2025/10/21/nfl-sees-a-surge-in-returns-with-the-new-dynamic-kickoff-onside-kicks-remain-a-concern/>.

²⁵CBS Sports, on the Eagles' and others' fourth-and-long onside alternatives (proposed in 2019 and by the Eagles in 2020, 2021, 2023 and 2024; none adopted): <https://www.cbssports.com/nfl/news/eagles-onside-kick-alternative-among-several-rule-change-proposals-submitted-by-nfl-teams>.

Common misconception

“An onside kick is a desperation play that works about one time in five.” It used to work more often than that, especially as a surprise. Under the declared-onside rules, it works roughly one time in ten or worse, because the receiving team is never surprised and the kicking team has no running start. The 2026 rule that lets a team declare one *at any time* does not bring the surprise back; it only removes the requirement to be losing.

Field position, kickoff by kickoff: what it adds up to

Pull the threads together. In 2025 the average drive after a kickoff started at the 30.3, against 25.1 in 2023 (onside kicks and return touchdowns excluded).²⁶ Five yards a kickoff is worth about 0.3 expected points to the receiving team (the difference between first-and-10 at the 25 and at the 30), and with eight or nine kickoffs in a typical game that is two or three points a game, split between the two teams. It is not huge, but it is real, and it is why the strategy around the play now matters: the best kicking unit of 2025 held opponents about two yards below the league average after its kickoffs, and the worst gave up about three yards more. Over a season that gap is worth more than a few field goals.

There is a quieter consequence too. A drive that starts at the 30 instead of the 25 is that much closer to field-goal range. Fourth-down and end-of-half decisions in Clock and Game Management start from where the drive started, and the dynamic kickoff moved that starting point up the field.

Film room: New Orleans Saints 2024

What happened: in the first season of the dynamic kickoff, many teams simply kicked into the end zone and took the touchback at the 30. The Saints’ Blake Grupe went the other way: in Week 1 every one of his first nine kickoffs landed at or inside the 5-yard line.²⁷ Over the season, the Saints’ opponents started their drives after kickoffs at the 28.2 on average, the best in the league; the league average was the 29.6.²⁸

What to notice: on a Saints kickoff, watch the ball, not the returner. Where does it come down (near the goal line, not the 15)? How long does it hang? Is the coverage arriving as it is caught? That combination, a kick that lands deep in the landing zone with the coverage already moving, was the blueprint other teams copied once the touchback moved to the 35.

Film room: Seattle Seahawks 2025

What happened: the Super Bowl LX champions also had the best kickoff field position in the league in 2025. Their opponents started drives after Seattle kickoffs at the 28.0 on average, about two yards better than the league average of 30.3, and only 12% of their kickoffs were touchbacks.²⁹ Kicker Jason Myers, who set a Super Bowl record with five field goals in Super Bowl LX, kicked off for them.³⁰

What to notice: pick any Seattle game from 2025 and keep the field-position ledger from Watch for it below for both teams’ kickoffs. Note where Seattle’s kicks land and how quickly its unblocked cover men (the far-side players and the kicker) close; then compare with the opponent’s kickoffs in the same game.

²⁶Course calculation (method as above): the average drive start after kickoffs, by season, in the chart earlier in the chapter.

²⁷The Ringer (Sept 12, 2024), cited above: “every single one of his first nine kicks landed either at or inside of the 5-yard line.”

²⁸Course calculation (method as above): 2024 drive starts after each team’s kickoffs.

²⁹Course calculation (method as above): 2025 drive starts and touchback rates after each team’s kickoffs, as in the scatter chart earlier in the chapter.

³⁰Super Bowl LX, February 8, 2026: Seattle 29, New England 13; Jason Myers kicked a Super Bowl-record five field goals: https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_LX.

Film room: Chicago Bears 2024, Week 1

What happened: in the first regular-season week of the dynamic kickoff, the Bears popped a good return against Tennessee by having two blockers double-team one cover man, pulling one of them across from the front line to do it. Analysts singled it out, and within a week at least eight other teams had tried similar double-team schemes.³¹

What to notice: on any 2025 or 2026 return, look for two receiving players lined up close together across from one cover man, or one blocker who moves sideways at the catch instead of straight ahead. That pair is the point of attack, and the returner's lane will be beside it.

Film room: New Orleans Saints, Super Bowl XLIV (2009 season)

What happened: the Saints opened the second half of Super Bowl XLIV, on February 7, 2010, with a surprise onside kick. Thomas Morstead's short kick bounced off a Colts player and New Orleans recovered, then drove for a touchdown in a 31-17 win.³² Sean Payton's call, known as "Ambush," is still the most famous onside kick ever.

What to notice: everything that made it work is now illegal or gone. The Colts' return team was set up for a deep kick, with no hands team on the field, because nobody expected an onside kick to open a half while a team was trailing by only four. Under the declared-onside rule that surprise cannot happen; the officials would tell the receiving team, and the hands team would trot on.

Watch for it

On Sunday: the field-position ledger. Kickoffs come in bunches (after every score and to start each half), so there is time to read each one.

Before the kick

- Count the receiving team's players on its 35 and the floaters behind them. Under the 2026 rules expect five on the line and up to four behind. Is there a pair of floaters close together across from one cover man? That is a likely double team, and the return will probably go beside it.
- How many returners? Two deep usually means a standard return; one deep with an extra blocker up front can mean the team expects a short or squib kick.
- Late in a half, or with a dangerous returner: expect a squib or a kick away from him.

While the ball is in the air

- Where does it come down? End zone in the air (kneel = the 35), landing zone and roll-in (kneel = the 20), landing zone (must return), or short (ball at the 40).
- Count the hang time if you can: a kick that hangs four seconds and comes down at the 3 gives the coverage time to arrive.

After the play

- Write down the starting yard line. Do it for every kickoff by both teams, and average each column at the end of the game.
- Compare with the league average: about the 30 in 2025. A team that is consistently two yards better on kickoffs than its opponent is gaining something like half a point a game, quietly.
- Did a returner run a ball out of the end zone and get stopped short of the 35? That is a mistake worth noting.

³¹The Ringer (Sept 12, 2024), cited above, crediting ESPN's Ben Solak for highlighting the Bears' double team against Tennessee in Week 1.

³²Pro Football Reference, Super Bowl XLIV box score (Feb 7, 2010; New Orleans 31, Indianapolis 17): <https://www.pro-football-reference.com/boxscores/201002070clt.htm>; "Super Bowl XLIV," *Wikipedia* (the "Ambush" onside kick by Thomas Morstead to open the second half): https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Super_Bowl_XLIV.

Predict the play

💡 Predict the play

Drill 1. Kneel or run? The kickoff comes down at the 4, bounces once and skips into the end zone, where the returner picks it up three yards deep. Under the 2026 rules, should he take a knee or run it out? Would your answer change if the same kick had come down in the end zone on the fly?

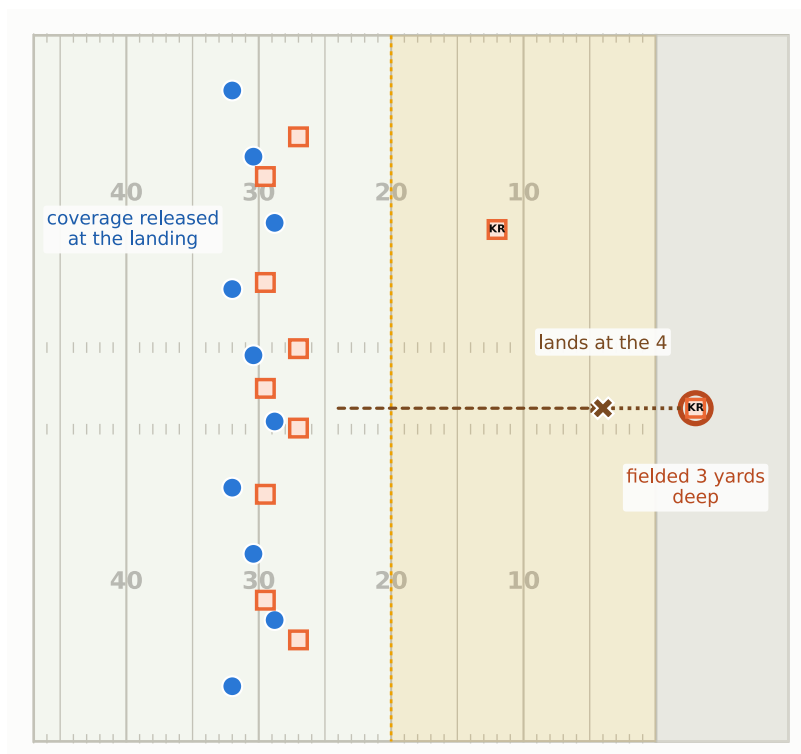


Figure 9: Drill 1: the kick comes down at the receiving team's 4 (X), inside the landing zone, and rolls into the end zone (dotted), where the returner (KR) picks it up three yards deep. The coverage was released when the ball landed and is closing. Kneel or run?

Answer 1 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play

Drill 2. Twenty-two seconds. It's the end of the first half. You have just kicked a field goal to go up 13-10 with 0:22 left, and you are about to kick off. The other team has one timeout and a dangerous returner. Under the 2026 rules, what kind of kickoff do you want, and what do you want to avoid?

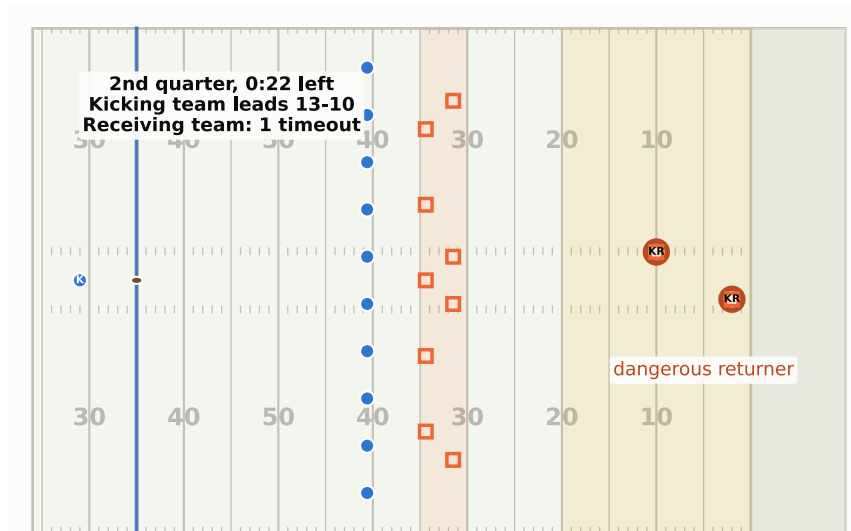


Figure 10: Drill 2: the kickoff after a field goal with 0:22 left in the first half; the kicking team leads 13-10 and the receiving team has one timeout. Both units are in the standard dynamic-kickoff alignment (2026 rules). What should the kicker do?

Answer 2 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

💡 Predict the play

Drill 3. Down eight, a minute left. You have just scored a touchdown, but the two-point try failed, and you trail by 8 with 1:01 left in the fourth quarter. You have no timeouts. Do you kick off deep or declare an onside kick? If you declare it, what will the receiving team put on the field, and what are your chances?

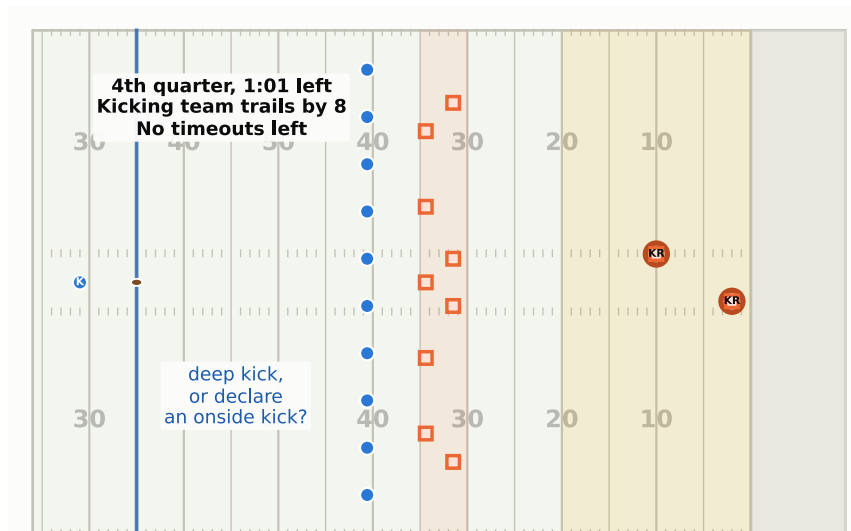


Figure 11: Drill 3: trailing by 8 with 1:01 left and no timeouts, the kicking team has to decide before it lines up: the normal dynamic-kickoff alignment for a deep kick (shown), or a declared outside kick?

Answer 3 is at the end of the chapter. Try it first.

Takeaways

- A **kickoff** is a free kick that trades field position after a score. For fifteen years the league made it safer by making it disappear, until only about a quarter of kickoffs were returned in 2023.
- The **dynamic kickoff** (2024) took away distance and speed instead: the coverage stands on the receiving team's 40, five yards from blockers in the **setup zone**, and nobody but the kicker and returners moves until the ball lands in the **landing zone**. Returns rose and kickoff concussions fell.
- The rules keep moving. **2025**: touchback to the 35, onside kicks declarable whenever trailing. **2026** (changed after the 2025 season): onside kicks declarable at any time, only five receivers on the restraining line with up to four floaters, and kicks from the 50 that go for a touchback or out of bounds spotted at the 20.
- The **touchback math** drives everything: in 2025 a returned kick started, on average, around the 29 to 31, short of the 35 a touchback gives, so kickers aim deep into the landing zone and returners should usually kneel on a ball that lands in the end zone, and run out one that rolled in.
- A return is now a **run play**: ten blockers for eleven cover men, so the scheme picks who to leave unblocked and spends the spare blocker on a **double team** at the point of attack.
- **Onside kicks** must be declared, so the **hands team** is always waiting and the surprise onside is gone. Recovery rates fell to around one in ten or worse.

Connections

Builds on: Field Goals, Extra Points, and the Punting Game (touchbacks, fair catches, the punt return and its wall), The Language of the Run Game (double teams, kick-outs, lead blocks and hat math, all reused in return blocking), and the expected-points curve in Downs, Distance, and Field Position.

Sets up:

- Contact Rules and Penalties as Strategy and Officials, Replay, and the Rules of the Ball: the penalties that move a kickoff to the 50, and the rules on loose balls and touchbacks.
- Clock and Game Management: kickoffs at the end of a half, onside decisions, and the fair-catch kick.
- Win Probability and Decision Analysis: when an onside kick is worth it.
- Appendix E, Rules, Timeline, and Coaching Trees: the kickoff rules in one table, current as of the 2026 season.

If you want to go deeper: the NFL's own explainers at NFL Football Operations (operations.nfl.com), which post each season's approved rule changes; The Ringer's 2024 guide to the dynamic kickoff and Sports Illustrated's "Happy Returns" (2024) for the coaches' view; and nflverse play-by-play, where every kickoff's description says where it landed and where it was returned to, so you can rebuild every chart in this chapter.

[i](#) Go deeper

From simulation to real tracking data. The return animation above is a gridiron simulation written in NFL Big Data Bowl coordinates. The 2022 Big Data Bowl was about special teams and released tracking data for every kickoff, punt and field goal from the 2018-2020 seasons, so you can draw real kickoffs with the same code. Those are traditional kickoffs, which makes them a good contrast with the simulated dynamic kickoff here. The data is on Kaggle and needs your own free login, so this code is not run when the book is built.

Answers to Predict the play

Answer 1.

Run it out. The kick came down in the landing zone before rolling into the end zone, so a knee gives his team the ball only at the 20. Almost any return beats that: returns fielded in the end zone averaged about the 26 in 2025, well past the 20. If the same kick had landed in the end zone on the fly, the knee would be worth the 35, and he should almost always take it: returns from the end zone averaged about the 26 in 2025 and reached the 35 only 9% of the time. This is the reason kickers love the line drive that lands at the 3 and skips in: it forces the returner either to accept the 20 or to run out from deep in his end zone.

Answer 2.

Kick into the landing zone and make them return it, or squib it; do not give them a touchback. A touchback hands the receiving team the ball at its 35 with all 22 seconds on the clock: two quick completions and it is in field-goal range. A kick that

has to be returned does two things for you. It usually ends short of the 35 (around the 28-30 on average in 2025), and the clock runs during the return, so a five- or six-second return leaves them about 16 seconds from somewhere near their 30. With one timeout that is barely enough time for two plays. Against a dangerous returner, many coaches go further and squib the ball or kick it toward a blocker or the other returner, giving up a couple of yards for the near-certainty that there is no long return. What you must avoid is the kick that lands short of the 20 or goes out of bounds: the ball at the 40 with 22 seconds left is a gift. The clock rules behind this are in Clock and Game Management.

Answer 3.

Declare the onside kick. If you kick deep with no timeouts, the other team takes a knee three times and the game is over; your only hope of getting the ball back is to recover the kick. The receiving team knows it is coming (the kick had to be declared), so it puts its hands team on the field: receivers, tight ends, backs and defensive backs, players chosen for their hands rather than their blocking. Your kicker will aim a hard, hopping kick toward one sideline so his fastest players can get to it just past the 10-yard line. Your chances are poor: under the declared- onside rules, kicking teams recovered 6% of onside kicks in 2024 and 10% in 2025. Poor beats zero, though. With more time and timeouts (say 3:30 and three timeouts) the answer flips: kick deep, play defense, and use the timeouts to get the ball back with good field position, because a failed onside kick hands the other team the ball near midfield. Where exactly the line falls is a win probability question.